

lets you access them via a single remote control.

Its key features include mid to high-end processors, adequate memory, high-capacity hard drives, advanced graphics and audio, optical drives and networking capabilities. It may also include a remote controller, a TV tuner and hardware encoder to capture and record TV signals, and TV and digital audio outputs to integrate with your TV and home theatre.

HCL Infosystems was the first Indian vendor to announce the launch of a Media Center PC in late 2003. Its latest model features an Intel P4 2.66 GHz CPU with 256 MB DDR RAM, an 80 GB hard drive along with a combo drive. Priced close to Rs 70,000, it has a full-featured Media Center remote control and Altec Lansing ATP3 2.1 speakers.

Other options in India include offerings from AOpen, MSI and HP. A recently announced model from HP boasts of running Windows XP Media Center Edition on an Intel P4 3.2 GHz CPU with the latest Intel 915P chipset to power high-definition video and audio. Also featuring an inbuilt wireless 802.11 b/g with a soft access point, it includes a 160 GB SATA hard drive, an 8X double-layer DVD Writer and a 9-in-1 digital media reader. However, it may be at least another three months before this model is introduced in India.



HCL Beanstalk Media Center PC

Media Center Software

The software bundled displays all entertainment options in a simple interface, called the 10-foot User interface, since you can manipulate it via a remote control from that distance. Below are entertainment options that accompany a superior Media Center software:

1. TV
2. Scheduled recording of TV signal
3. Pause live-TV
4. Music organisation and playback
5. Video/movie playback
6. FM Tuner
7. Picture mode with slideshow

Some of the software that offer the above functionalities are:

Windows XP Media Center Edition

This Windows XP-variant provides a range of entertainment options in a unified interface. Wizards help you set up the media center, calibrate your display device and set up TV input from a cable, antenna, satellite or set-top box. An enhanced 16:9 visual support, adaptive de-interlacing and video-scaling, automatic guide updates, parental controls, and storage management for recorded content provides complete control. However, the Media Center Edition only

The Media Center software displays entertainment options in a '10-foot User interface'

The DIY approach

You don't really need to spend your money on readymade solutions to have Media Center capabilities. If you own a decently configured PC (a P4 processor, 256 MB of DDR memory, a large capacity 7200-rpm hard drive, a DVD-ROM/Combo/DVD-Writer), you can easily convert it to a media center PC. All you require is a decent TV-tuner card with a bundled remote, FM tuner and compatible software. Just plug in the TV tuner, install the drivers and software, and scan for channels. That's it, your own Personal Video Recorder solution



comes pre-installed on PC systems.

Intervideo Home Theatre

Known for its WinDVD software, Intervideo offers a not-too-innovative nomenclature of Home Theatre. The package converts your PC into a VCR, DVD player, photo album, radio and music box.

CyberLink PowerCinema

It supports movies, music and pictures as well as TV and Radio in the TV Plus Edition. Features include a Favourite List Manager for stations and a 12-station preview to ease channel-surfing.

Showshifter

This package offers features such as pausing live-TV, digital video-recording, electronic program guide, home-networking compatibility, DVD playback, remote-control compatibility, music jukebox and CD player functionalities-all in a single and easy-to-use interface.

Apart from the above, most TV tuner cards are bundled with remote controllers and software that can accomplish at least some of the above tasks.

Displays

Home entertainment is not complete without a proper display. It can be your CRT or LCD monitor, or a regular TV. Opt for the large screen rear-projection TV or a Plasma TV display for the 'inhouse' theatre ambience. Plasma and LCD displays are now available in sizes never thought possible. LCD and Plasma are actually two different display technologies, each with its own advantages and disadvantages.

LCDs use a fluorescent backlight to send light through the liquid crystal molecules and a polarising substrate. A voltage applied to red,



Samsung 17 inch LCD TV